

CHAPTER 05

THE CULTURE OF PAKISTAN



MULTIPLE CHOICE QUESTIONS

1. The new art created after the Muslim invasion in South Asia is called _____.
2. Shahi Qila (Royal Fort) was built by _____.
3. Wazir Khan Mosque is located in _____.
4. Mahabat Khan Mosque is located in _____.
5. Moen-jo-Daro is situated in the district of _____.
6. Jamia Mosque Thatta was constructed during the reign of _____.
7. Badshahi Mosque in Lahore was built during the reign of _____.
8. The National Anthem of Pakistan was written by _____.
9. Ajrak is the cultural symbol of the province _____.
10. The cultural center of Gandhara Art was _____.
11. The city famous for sports goods in Pakistan is _____.
12. Shalimar Bagh is situated in _____.
13. The city known as the "City of Saints" is _____.

SHORT ANSWERS

Definition of Culture:

Culture is a broad and complex concept that encompasses the customs, beliefs, values, and practices shared by a society. It can be simply defined as *"the social heritage of a community"* or *"the complete way of life of a people."* According to the cultural theorist Muller-Layer, *"Culture is an aggregate means of achievement and of progress."*

In the context of Pakistan Studies, culture is not just a reflection of social norms, but it is deeply rooted in the religious, historical, and ideological foundations of the country. Pakistan's culture is a manifestation of its Islamic identity, historical experiences, and regional diversity.

Salient Features of Pakistani Culture:

To understand Pakistani society effectively, it is important to analyze the distinct characteristics of its culture. The major features of Pakistani culture are as follows:

1. Religious Uniformity:

The most significant aspect of Pakistani culture is its religious foundation. Pakistan was established in 1947 as a separate homeland for Muslims of the Indian subcontinent. The objective was to provide a social, political, and economic system based on the principles of Islam. Despite the presence of linguistic and ethnic diversity, the people of Pakistan are united under the banner of Islam. Islamic teachings shape the values, ethics, laws, and day-to-day life of the citizens. Religious festivals like Eid-ul-Fitr, Eid-ul-Adha, and religious practices such as prayer, fasting, and charity are common across the nation.

2. Common Language – Urdu:

Pakistan is a multi-lingual country where several regional languages are spoken such as Punjabi, Sindhi, Pashto, Balochi, Saraiki, and others. However, Urdu serves as the national and official language, understood and spoken throughout the country. Urdu not only facilitates communication among people of different provinces but also plays a unifying role by serving as a symbol of national identity. It promotes national integration and reflects the literary and cultural heritage of Pakistan.

3. Traditional Dress:

Dress is a visible expression of cultural identity. In Pakistan, traditional attire varies from

region to region depending on climate, customs, and lifestyle. However, the Shalwar Qameez is the national dress and is commonly worn by both men and women in all provinces. Cultural attire often includes regional variations such as turbans, waistcoats, dupattas, and embroidery styles that represent local traditions and aesthetic preferences.

4. Dietary Habits:

Food habits in Pakistan are closely linked with Islamic values, economic conditions, and regional availability. The general diet includes wheat, rice, meat, pulses, and vegetables, accompanied by milk, tea, lassi, and other local beverages. Pork and alcohol are strictly avoided as per Islamic teachings. Social etiquettes surrounding food—such as eating with the right hand and beginning meals with a prayer—also reflect Islamic cultural values.

5. Mixed Cultural Influences:

Although Pakistan is predominantly a Muslim country, its culture exhibits influences from various historical backgrounds, particularly from Hindu and British civilizations due to its colonial past and centuries of interaction with the Indian subcontinent. These influences can be seen in architecture, legal systems, education, dress styles, and some social customs. However, the core values of Pakistani culture remain rooted in Islamic teachings.

6. Recreational and Sports Activities:

Sports and recreational activities form an important part of cultural expression. Pakistan has a rich tradition of sports, both modern and traditional. Games such as cricket, hockey, squash, football, kabaddi, and wrestling are widely played and followed. These activities not only provide entertainment but also reflect community bonding and regional pride. Some sports like cricket and hockey have also brought international recognition to Pakistan, strengthening its national image.

Conclusion:

Pakistani culture is deeply intertwined with Islamic principles and reflects the ideological basis of the country. It encompasses all aspects of life, including religion, traditions, customs, language, dress, food, art, and architecture. The Islamic code of conduct governs social interactions, moral obligations, and lifestyle practices. Despite influences from various historical and regional sources, the essence of Pakistani culture remains Islamic. It represents the collective identity of the people of Pakistan and serves as a guiding framework for social harmony and national unity.

Cultural Heritage of Pakistan

Pakistan is home to a rich and diverse cultural heritage that reflects its historical, religious, and artistic traditions. The land that is now Pakistan has been the cradle of several ancient civilizations and has preserved its legacy through archaeological remains, architectural marvels, fine arts, and traditional crafts. The cultural heritage of Pakistan can be broadly classified into the following categories:

Archaeological Heritage

Pakistan's archaeological heritage stretches back over five millennia, showcasing the

rise and fall of ancient civilizations that once flourished in the region. Key archaeological sites include:

1. Moen-jo-Daro:

Located in Sindh, this city was a major urban center of the Indus Valley Civilization, dating back approximately 4,000 years (around 2600 BCE). Its well-planned streets, advanced drainage systems, and large public buildings reflect a highly developed society.

2. Harappa:

Situated near Sahiwal in Punjab, Harappa was another significant city of the Indus Valley Civilization. Excavations have revealed a similar urban structure to Moen-jo-Daro, with evidence of trade, writing, and organized governance.

3. Gandhara Civilization:

Flourishing between the 2nd and 5th centuries CE, the Gandhara region (primarily in present-day Khyber Pakhtunkhwa) was a center of Greco-Buddhist art. It played a key role in spreading Buddhism to Central and East Asia.

4. Buddhist Remains:

Found extensively in the northwestern region (Khyber Pakhtunkhwa), especially around Swat and Takht-i-Bahi, these ruins date back to 2nd to 5th centuries CE, showcasing stupas, monasteries, and intricate sculptures.

5. Taxila:

An ancient city located near Rawalpindi, Taxila was a hub of learning and culture in ancient times. The site includes Buddhist stupas, monasteries, and ancient Hindu temples, reflecting a rich mix of religious influences.

6. Thatta:

Once the capital of Sindh, Thatta is known for its historical monuments, especially the Shah Jahan Mosque, built in the 17th century. This mosque is renowned for its beautiful blue tile work and acoustics.

Architectural Heritage

Pakistan boasts a variety of architectural styles influenced by Islamic, Mughal, Persian, and regional traditions. Some notable examples include:

- **Lahore Fort:** A UNESCO World Heritage Site, this massive fortress has undergone several modifications by Mughal emperors and showcases exquisite Mughal architecture.
- **Badshahi Mosque:** One of the largest mosques in the world, built by Emperor Aurangzeb in Lahore. It is known for its grandeur and red sandstone structure.
- **Tomb of Jahangir:** Located in Shahdara, Lahore, this is the burial place of the Mughal Emperor Jahangir, surrounded by lush gardens and intricate Mughal architecture.
- **Shalimar Gardens:** These terraced gardens in Lahore were built by Emperor Shah Jahan and are a classic example of Persian-style Mughal gardens.
- **Wazir Khan Mosque:** Built in the 17th century, this mosque is famous for its vibrant frescoes and tile mosaics, located within the Walled City of Lahore.
- **Golden Mosque (Sunehri Masjid):** A small but elegant mosque with golden domes, located in Lahore.
- **Mahabat Khan Mosque:** Situated in Peshawar, this mosque is a masterpiece of Mughal

architecture built in the 17th century.

• **Bala Hissar Fort:** Located in Peshawar, this fort has historical significance and served as the royal residence of Durrani kings.

Heritage in Fine Arts

Pakistan has a deep-rooted tradition of fine arts, which reflects both historical influences and regional diversity. The major domains include:

a) Painting

The art of painting in South Asia evolved gradually, with Islamic influences promoting geometric and floral patterns rather than figurative work. Early examples can be seen in decorative wall and ceiling paintings found in palaces and mosques, especially during the Mughal era.

b) Calligraphy

Islamic calligraphy is a prominent art form in Pakistan. Mosques, manuscripts, and public buildings are often adorned with Arabic and Persian calligraphy, especially verses from the Quran. Calligraphy flourished particularly during the Mughal period and continues to be an important cultural symbol.

c) Music

Pakistan has inherited a rich musical heritage, especially from the Mughal court traditions. Classical musicians such as Amir Khusro (credited with inventing several ragas and musical instruments) and Tansen (one of the nine jewels of Akbar's court) are revered figures. Traditional music forms like Qawwali, Ghazal, and folk music remain integral to Pakistani culture.

d) Architecture and Sculpture

Islamic architecture in Pakistan combines functional design with artistic expression. From towering domes to intricate tile work and stucco carvings, the architectural heritage also includes sculptures and miniature art developed under Buddhist and Gandhara influence. The region's historical Buddhist sculptures, particularly from Taxila and Swat, are renowned globally for their craftsmanship and blend of Greek and Indian styles.